

LONDON ROAD SURGERY

Website: www.thelondonroadsurgery.co.uk

Telephone: 01268 765533

NEWSLETTER February 2025

Welcome to the practice newsletter. In it you will find some useful information, especially if you are not able to use a computer. However, there are references to important websites and it might be useful if you have a friend or relative who could gain access to the relevant information for you. This is a bumper issue this month as there are lots of campaigns listed for March 2025. Please see end of the newsletter.

All prescription requests must be made online via the NHS App or via Online Services accessed by using the London Road Surgery website. Alternatively, you can post your request through our letterbox or send it by Royal Mail.

We are experiencing a high demand for appointments please ask your local Pharmacist for advice or use e-consult online consultation and receive a reply within 48 hours. Pharmacy First is a new campaign that allows the Pharmacists to treat 7 conditions. Please ask your pharmacist for more information.

e-consults or Online Consultations

We have available via the website www.thelondonroadsurgery.co.uk a platform for consulting online a clinical or admin queries. This is called e-consult. Please follow the instructions to submit your query. You will get a response within 48 hours.

New Reception Staff

We have new staff who have joined our reception team. Please be patient while they deal with your queries. Our reception staff are now called Healthcare Navigators because they can sign post you to Health Care Professionals who support the doctors in primary care.

Thank you for your kind comments for some of our new reception staff.

These staff are trained professionals and if unable to support you they will refer you back to the doctor. These are: Pharmacists, Paramedic, Social Prescriber, Mental Health First Contact Practitioner, and retail Pharmacists. We also use the weekend appointments available to all the practices in Wickford.

Ideas and Suggestions

Please let us know if you have any ideas or suggestions by writing to us via the email address or by post.

Thank you.

Veteran Friendly Accreditation

We are accredited as an Armed Forces veteran friendly accredited GP practice. Dr Richards is the Lead GP for this.

Patient Contact Details

Please keep us up to date with your contact details either by popping a note through our letterbox or by emailing us at londonroadsurgery@nhs.net

Last month we had 660 patients with no mobile number on their record. Please email us with your mobile number and email address.

Primary Care Network (PCN) Staff

In line with NHS England guidance and the development of Primary Care Networks (PCN's) some new allied Health Care Professionals have joined the team at London Road Surgery. We have a Paramedic and 2 Advanced Nurse Practitioners who can treat minor illness. We also have a Nurse Practitioner who is studying to become an Advanced Nurse Practitioner. These staff members join the doctors and nurses and the new Social Prescriber and Mental Health First Contact Practitioner to help you. NEW – we have a Physio who works here on Tuesday and Friday who you can see by booking in with reception.

To assist you with your request to see a clinician our Receptionists/Care Navigators will ask you the reason for your appointment so that they can guide you to the correct clinician for your condition.

PCN Pharmacists – now work at the surgery and you may be contacted by them before you see a doctor. They can sort minor illnesses as well as review all medication.

We encourage self-care and there are lots of information on our website and NHS App.

Local Pharmacists are happy to discuss with you about your minor illness and we can refer you to them using our clinical system. They will call you back in a few hours.

Basildon & Brentwood CCG website also has Health Information

<https://basildonandbrentwoodccg.nhs.uk/>

Looking after yourself

We continue to offer free health checks for patients aged 40-74 who have not had a health check in 5 years and for those over 75 years.
Please call reception to book your health check with Natalie or Mel our Paramedic.

Contacting Us

Please do not use our email address to send any clinical queries to us. Please call the practice to make an appointment or use e-consult (see above). Please use NHS App to order repeat medication. We can process requests faster this way.

Patient Group Activity

We have a new noticeboard in our Waiting Room and the Chair – Sue Bunney will be coordinating new campaigns for the group to action. They have recently done a survey and their minutes are on our website. The group will be promoting the NHS App.

Next Patient Group meeting: Monday 24 March 2025 at 2pm
All are welcome!

Patient Newsletter on Website

We understand that lots of our patients are unable to view our website if you know a member of your community is housebound or without any computer access, please print this and deliver it to them. London Road Surgery thank you for this kindness.

Healthwatch Essex

<https://healthwatchessex.org.uk/>

Is an independent charity set up under the Health & Social Care Act 2012 and they

use your voice to improve health and care in Essex. They undertake high-quality research and engagement to uncover your experience of services and use it to shape health and care. They are also proud hosts to the Essex Neurology Network.

They can help you find out about and access health and social care services through our Information & Guidance Service. **Call 0300 500 1895, text 07712395398** between 10am and 2pm on Monday, Wednesday and Friday. Outside of those times, you can use it to leave them a message. Check out how to get involved!

info@healthwatchessex.org.uk

Message on **07712395398**, Monday - Friday, 9am to 4:30pm

Looking After Your Mental Wellbeing

Looking after our mental wellbeing sometimes falls behind on our list of priorities. But keeping mentally well helps us to keep physically well too. Visit this website for some tips on how to look after your mind: <https://www.nhs.uk/oneyou/every-mind-matters/>

Free listening services

These services offer confidential advice from trained volunteers. You can talk about anything that is troubling you, no matter how difficult:

Call 116 123 to talk to Samaritans, or email: jo@samaritans.org for a reply within 24 hours.

Text "SHOUT" to 85258 to contact the Shout Crisis Text Line, or text "YM" if you're under 19.

If you are under 19, you can also call 0800 1111 to talk to Childline. The number will not appear on your phone bill.

The Essex Wellbeing Service 0300 303 9988

We provide Essex residents (excluding Southend-On-Sea and Thurrock) with access to health checks; stop smoking services; weight management courses; and emotional health and wellbeing support.

We also support Essex organisations at work via our three-tiered Working Well Accreditation. This consists of workplace health and wellbeing sessions; Mental Health First Aid training; and the Working Well Accreditation itself where organisations can be recognised for their commitment to staff health and wellbeing.

EWS also runs a volunteering service where we recruit and connect volunteers with Essex residents in need of support with everyday tasks, social isolation and making long-term friendships.

The Service is commissioned by Essex County Council. But we couldn't do this without our amazing alliance of partners...

Provide CIC

Provide CIC is a Community Interest Company (social enterprise) that delivers a broad range of health and social care services in the community throughout Essex, Cambridgeshire and East Anglia.

Provide works from a variety of community settings, such as three community hospitals, community clinics, schools, nursing homes and primary care settings, as well as within people's homes to provide more than 40 services to children, families and adults.

Provide CIC has been commissioned by Essex County Council to deliver the Essex Wellbeing Service, in partnership with all the organisations listed on this page.

Priority Digital Health

Priority Digital Health (PDH) build digital solutions which empower better self-management and service-management of patients' health and wellbeing.

PDH ensures people get the help and support they need, swiftly, whilst remaining true to their 'Tell Your Story Once' mantra.

PDH's speciality is disease prevention; their background is in changing behaviour, and their focus is cost-saving and service efficiencies – but not at the expense of user experience.

They have three main products: The Priority Platform (customisable case management software); Diabetes Book & Learn (connecting people with Diabetes to the right education); and AmaraHealth™ (a whole-body health and wellbeing app).

For Essex Wellbeing Service, PDH provides the case management system that digitises lifestyle bookings; volunteer sign-up and management; and referral or self-referral for support with everyday tasks.

PDH provides their marketing services for the EWS and Working Well website and social media. EWS also have access to PDH's AmaraHealth™ app where Essex residents can track, analyse, and manage their whole-body health inside one app.

Age Well East

Age Well East offers community friendship services to anyone in Essex who is over 18 with an aim to end loneliness. They provide one to one volunteer friendship (befriending), pen friending and access to social groups and activities to empower people to live happier and healthier.

Age Well East believes everyone deserves to age well and they have been empowering people in later years since 1950. Their knowledgeable staff and volunteers provide excellent support services which are easily available.

They understand that changes in circumstances make people particularly susceptible to loneliness. When left ignored, loneliness can escalate from a temporary situation to a chronic challenge, which the NHS estimates as having the same detrimental impact as smoking 15 cigarettes a day on health deterioration. In Essex alone, as many as 80,000 people are thought to be lonely, which is one of many reasons Age Well East is so committed to providing excellent and trusted support.

HCRG Care Group

HCRG Care Group changes lives by transforming health and care. They are one of the UK's leading independent providers of community health and care services, working with health and care commissioners and communities to transform services with a focus on experience, efficiency and improved outcomes.

The children and family healthy lifestyle service is here to support your family in making long term, sustainable adjustments to suit your lifestyle. If you are unsure if your child is within the healthy weight range, you can check their body mass index (BMI) using the NHS BMI Calculator. The calculator takes into account your child's age and sex as well as their height and weight.

If you find your child is outside the healthy weight range - don't panic! There are lots that the team can do to support you in making healthier lifestyle choices and to help your child achieve a healthier weight as they grow.

Being active and making balanced food choices is important, but HCRG Care Group will work with your family to make sure our support is the right offer for you and your family.

HCRG Care Group's teams have lots of resources that they would like to make available to your family. If you would like to register your interest or find out more about what HCRG can offer your family, please contact EWS.

HCRG Care Group also runs Essex Child and Family Wellbeing Service on behalf of Essex County Council.

Rural Community Council of Essex

Many Essex villages exude an air of prosperity. However, behind the affluent facade there is evidence of hidden deprivation, and with it the potential for people to be unreasonably disadvantaged by living in a rural location.

Rural communities are the reason for the existence of the Rural Community Council of Essex (RCCE) and remain the focus of the vast majority of their work, but they do provide some services, notably Community Agents Essex and United in Kind Coaches on a countywide basis.

Rural Community Council of Essex (RCCE) works to provide local communities with the skills, resources and expertise necessary to achieve a thriving and sustainable future.

RCCE provides support and facilitation for local community organisations and projects; develops initiatives that improve the life chances of disadvantaged people and families; and provides an influential voice for rural communities in Essex.

Part of their attention focuses on helping people who may experience disadvantage and exclusion through factors such as low wage employment, the high cost of housing, lack of access to essential services and a scarcity of public transport.

Terrence Higgins Trust

Terrence Higgins Trust (THT) team of specialist health and wellbeing coaches will work to re-engage those who have disengaged from or who have lost trust in the system.

The service works closely with a diverse range of populations across Essex, and in partnership with the wider EWS service to maximize opportunities for LGBT+, Traveller, Roma, and Racially Minoritised communities, as well as Drug and Alcohol Misusers, Homeless / those at risk of Homelessness, as well as those within the criminal justice system.

THT believes that involving and empowering local communities, particularly disadvantaged groups, and young people is central to both promotion of excellent Health and Wellbeing and the reduction of health inequalities.

THT champions that partnership approaches to service delivery, combined with innovation, improve engagement with service users, contribute to directly addressing marginalisation and powerlessness underpinning health and social inequalities and are effective in building sustainable communities.

THT is also the UK's largest HIV and Sexual and Reproductive Health charity.

Building upon the already excellent established working relationship between THT and Provide in Essex the THT Essex Wellbeing Service (EWS) partnership will engage with and empower Seldom Heard From Communities.

Services

- Stop Smoking
- Physical Activity
- Social Isolation
- Mental Health
- Alcohol Reduction
- Sleep
- Health Checks
- Child Lifestyle Service

- Weight Management

T: 0300 303 9988

E: provide.essexwellbeing@nhs.net

Opening Hours

Monday to Friday 8.00am - 7.00pm

Saturday 9.00am to 12.00pm

All enquiries, will be responded to during the opening hours above

Complaints / Feedback

T: 0300 303 9951

E: provide.customerservices@nhs.net

NHS App

If you have a smartphone, you can download the NHS App which allows you to order repeat prescriptions and book appointments quickly and easily.

We encourage use of the NHS App as this saves time for the patients. It will integrate with secondary care so you can see future hospital appointments.

Contact Details

Don't forget to let us know if you have new phone number or change address. You can email us or call us.

The Good Grief Trust

Website www.thegoodgrieftrust.org

If you have been affected by a sudden bereavement during this crisis and need support, advice and guidance.

PLEASE CALL; SUDDEN BEREAVEMENT HELP 0800 2600 400.
OPERATING HOURS: 10AM – 4PM MONDAY – FRIDAY.

Mental Health Information

VitaMinds offer a free and confidential NHS Service and Psychological talking therapies. They offer support for Anxiety, Low mood, Depression, Panic attacks, Social anxiety, sleep problems, PTSD, OCD and specific phobias. You can self-refer online vitahealthgroup.co.uk or call 01268 977 171 Monday – Friday 8am – 8pm and Saturdays 9am – 12.30pm or Out of Hours emotional support 24/7 01268 977 171

Contact Us Online

We have updated our website and added a tab called Contact Us Online. This is for patients to send us administrative queries or medical issues. Hopefully this will free up our phone lines for those patients without internet access.

Useful Telephone Numbers

Boots Allianz The Wick	01268 574018
Boots Mayflower	01268 820235
Boots Willowdale	01268 761911
Co-op	01268 970532
Garbetts	01268 732042
Medipharm	01268 735777
Sainsbury's	01268 270282
Shadforth's	01268 733313
Shotgate	01268 768547
Tesco Mayflower	01268 367647
Wells Pharmacy	01268 762605

CARING FOR OTHERS

If you are caring for a relative, you can access information & advice, specialist support, groups & activities through Carers First. Carers First is a charity commissioned by Essex County Council:

Telephone: 0300 303 1555

Email: hello@CarersFIRST.org.uk

Please let us know if you are an unpaid Carer and if you need support

Useful Resources:

Alzheimer's Society: 01245 260911 3 Lockside Marina Chelmsford CM2 6HF

National Domestic Violence Helpline: 0808 2000 247

<https://www.nationaldahelpline.org.uk>

NSPCC helpline: 0808 800 5000

ChildLine: 0800 1111

MIND: www.mind.org.uk

YoungMinds: <https://youngminds.org.uk>

ICON: Babies cry: You can cope <https://iconcope.org>

IRISi: irisi.org/iris/find-your-local-iris-site

March 2025

International Prenatal Infection Prevention Month

Prenatal Infection Prevention Month helps to promote awareness of infections transmitted from mother to baby. When you're pregnant, it's important to minimise the risk of becoming ill. In some cases, infections can transfer to your unborn baby, causing serious risks, so it's a good idea to take some extra precautions to keep you and your baby safe.

Here are a few useful tips to follow:

- Book your prenatal appointments
- Keep up to date with immunisations
- Practice good hygiene such as hand washing
- Eat a healthy diet
- Avoid environmental hazards such as cigarette smoke

<https://www.nhs.uk/pregnancy/keeping-well/infections-that-may-affect-your-baby/>

<https://www.nhsinform.scot/ready-st...our-baby/how-to-prevent-illness-in-pregnancy/>

Stay well in winter

Winter conditions can be bad for our health, aggravating any existing health problems, making us more vulnerable to respiratory winter illnesses. It's not just your physical health that can suffer during cold weather, it's important to think about your mental health too. Lack of sunlight, miserable weather and the cost of living can put a strain on our wellbeing. Have a look at these tips on practising self-care this winter.

<https://www.andovermind.org.uk/5-top-tips-to-take-care-of-your-wellbeing-this-winter/>

<https://www.england.nhs.uk/long-rea...well-this-winter-transcript-of-audio-version/>

For older patients

With the withdrawal of the winter fuel allowance, you may be feeling extra financial pressure when it comes to keeping warm this winter. If you're in receipt of a means-

tested benefit, you can still receive the winter fuel payment. But if you're not, or even if you'd just like to save some money while warming up, have a look at these cost-effective tips to warm you up during the cold winter months.

If you have health or mobility issues, it can be very difficult to get out and about to see people. Loneliness can take its toll on their mental health. No one deserves the sadness of feeling lonely. Find support here: <https://www.ageuk.org.uk/information-advice/money-legal/benefits-entitlements/winter-fuel-payment/>

<https://www.redcross.org.uk/stories/health-and-social-care/health/tips-on-keeping-warm-this-winter>

<https://www.ageuk.org.uk/information-advice/money-legal/benefits-entitlements/winter-fuel-payment/>

(If you know of any local groups, or have resources at your practice, add the links to this post in place of the national helpline.)

NHS App

If you're new to using the NHS App and you're not sure how to access the information, there is lots of information around to help you. Download the NHS App on your smartphone or tablet via the Google play or App store. You can also access the same services in a web browser by logging in through the NHS website.

Did you know that using the NHS App can help you access lots of information about your health?

- Request repeat prescriptions
- Check the status of your prescriptions
- See upcoming appointments
- View your health records

<https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-app/nhs-app-help-and-support/>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q0SCcLtw8JA>

Find your NHS Number

Need to know your NHS number but can't remember where you wrote it down? Don't worry! Find it here:

<https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/online-services/find-nhs-number/>

Tinnitus awareness, 3rd–9th February

Tinnitus is a condition that causes people to hear sounds in their ears, like ringing, buzzing or other disturbances, when there is no external sound. It can vary in levels, and can impact mood, sleep and concentration. Over a sustained period, it can cause hearing loss or increased sensitivity to noise. Living with this condition can be very

frustrating, and draining, so it may be useful to look at some self-help tips.

<https://tinnitus.org.uk/support-for-you/what-can-i-do/self-help-tips/>

World Cancer Day, 4th February

World Cancer Day is held to raise awareness, to encourage prevention, and to improve treatment and research. This year, the theme is ‘while cancer touches millions of lives in countless ways, it doesn’t define who a person is’, and it focuses on person-centred care. And don’t forget, if you’ve been diagnosed with cancer, you can find help and support from Macmillan.

#WorldCancerDay #UnitedByUnique

<https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-awareness/world-cancer-day>

<https://www.worldcancerday.org/the-campaign/what-people-centred-care>

Children’s Mental Health Week, 5th–11th February

The theme of this year’s Children’s Mental Health Week is ‘Know Yourself, Grow Yourself’, which is about encouraging children and young people across the UK to embrace self-discovery and growth. As parents, you can encourage your children to prioritise their wellbeing with these ideas:

- Keeping a journal about their feelings
- Going on a reflective walk, mindful colouring or a creative activity
- Being visual using flashcards or drawings to help express emotions
- Practising mindfulness
- Communicating

<https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/childrens-mental-health-support/supporting-a-child-or-young-person/>

National HIV Testing Week, 5th–11th February

Early detection of HIV is essential for helping you to remain healthy, preventing further spread of the virus. Evidence shows that starting anti-virals at an early stage can help long-term health outcomes. It’s quick and easy to get tested. You can even order a free kit during National HIV Testing Week this year.

<https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/hiv-and-aids/diagnosis/>

<https://www.tht.org.uk/news/national-hiv-testing-week-returns-2025>

Time to Talk Day, 6th February

#TimeToTalk Day is on 6th February! How will you have a conversation about mental health? This annual event is about being open to the idea of talking. If someone opens up about their mental health, it might not always feel easy to know what to say. But it doesn’t have to be awkward – just being there for someone can make a big difference.

<https://timetotalkday.co.uk/about/>

<https://timetotalkday.co.uk/tips-to-talk/>

International Epilepsy Day, 12th February

International Epilepsy Day seeks to raise awareness and educate the general public on the facts about epilepsy and the urgent need for improved treatment. There is still much misunderstanding and stigma surrounding epilepsy. Find out more and support those around you with this debilitating condition. The theme for International Epilepsy Day 2025 is 'My Epilepsy Journey'. Despite being one of the world's oldest-known medical conditions, fear and misunderstanding can make many people reluctant to talk about it. Help others to understand, and share your Epilepsy Journey.

<https://internationalepilepsyday.org/journey/>

<https://epilepsysociety.org.uk/>

Eating Disorders Awareness Week, 24th February–2nd March

In the UK, at least 1.25 million people are living with an eating disorder. That's at least one in 50 people, and the signs can be really difficult to spot. Although eating disorders are complex mental illnesses, they can affect anyone of any age, ethnicity, gender or background, and early intervention is essential. Discover more about how you can help those around you who may be suffering. #EDAW aims to improve awareness and help save lives. If you're worried that you're suffering from any form of eating disorder, we're here to listen and support you. Please make an appointment with our (Nurse/GP).

<https://edaw.beateatingdisorders.org.uk/>

Opening editorial

Renal cell carcinoma: standards and controversies

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The purpose of this topic issue of the *World Journal of Urology* is to relay novel developments and controversies in renal cell carcinoma (RCC). To achieve this, we have selected renowned experts to review the state-of-the-art on various scientific and clinical aspects of RCC. The pace of basic, translational and clinical RCC research development is rapid. We have selected, as outlined below, those topics where we felt that we must improve our knowledge and understanding to provide improved prevention, diagnostic and treatment strategies to our patients.

With the widespread use of modern cross-sectional abdominal imaging, the incidence of asymptomatic renal tumours has been increasing, especially in patients over the age of 70 [1, 2]. Many of these incidentalomas do not have and will not develop adverse pathological or clinical features meaning any intervention may not change the natural history of the disease. Unfortunately, while imaging is an essential part of the workup, precise criteria to determine the biology of a renal tumour are lacking [2]. However, this “opportunistic”, unspecific screening by non-urological specialities has decreased the number of patients presenting with advanced RCC [1], which results from a shift to an earlier stage where RCC is curable or does not cause harm if left alone. “Smart” ultrasound-based screening of a target population defined by established risk factors (age, sex, body mass index, smoking history) and promising plasma markers such as kidney injury molecule 1 [3] may be even more beneficial. Such a strategy may increase the incidence of the disease but would hopefully further decrease mortality rates. If we utilise renal tumour biopsy and active surveillance wisely, intervention rates will remain on a similar level. Overtreatment of screen-detected tumours must be avoided at all costs.

Research into the biology and the genetic basis of RCC has led to a greater understanding of molecular pathways, refinements in pathological classification, development of drugs and new prognostic factors. The trunk-branch model of key genetic events and heterogeneity is now generally accepted, with many of these events occurring years to decades before tumours become clinically evident [4]. Many more landmark studies will be published from the TRACERx Renal Consortium and other initiatives in the foreseeable future. The review article in this topic issue includes a summary of recent evidence, but also a methodological overview and a glossary of terms used to describe genetic changes [4]. We hope that this will serve as a comprehensive up-to-date resource for urologists, specifically for those not involved in genomic research. Similarly, the review on the most recent WHO classification,

staging and grading of renal tumours by Warren and Harrison [5] outlines standards and controversies from the perspective of pathologists. It remains important to look beyond our own immediate specialty to provide high quality care.

Despite several efforts with adjuvant phase III trials in high risk non-metastatic RCC, a clinically significant survival benefit has not yet been demonstrated and postoperative follow-up imaging remains the standard of care. Despite its importance in clinical practice, there is little high-quality evidence in this field. RECUR is a multicentre consortium which established collaborative research studies regarding postoperative follow-up, and lead investigators of this group provided a comprehensive review for this topic issue [6]. It is worth noting that established follow-up guidelines differ regarding frequency, type of imaging and prognostic stratification, and do not consider competing risks such as age and co-morbidity [6–8]. Further, there is little data regarding health-related quality of life outcomes after surgery [9]. Clearly, high quality evidence-based follow-up protocols are a research priority, but will rely on accurate prognostic stratification at baseline. This topic issue contains a literature review on prognostic factors and models, all of which have limited accuracy. Molecular markers can improve the accuracy of these models, but frequently lack external, independent validation [10]. Validation of molecular markers is another research priority, as one can regard only validated markers as biomarkers.

Another controversy is the use of cytoreductive nephrectomy in patients with synchronous metastatic RCC. The CARMENA trial showed that sunitinib alone is not inferior to cytoreductive nephrectomy and sunitinib for both intermediate and high risk metastatic clear cell RCC, which constitute more than 95% of newly diagnosed patients with metastatic disease [11]. Despite level I evidence, CARMENA had several limitations, and it is still thought that cytoreductive nephrectomy can prolong survival in select patients [12]. In particular, studies show that patients in a good performance status, with low metastatic burden and a predicted survival of over 12 months will most likely benefit from surgery [13, 14]. The preoperative MD Anderson nomogram is based on serum levels of albumin and lactate dehydrogenase and can estimate 6 months survival outcomes after cytoreductive nephrectomy [15]. In this issue, Marconi et al. [16] validated this nomogram in an independent cohort of 1100 patients and confirmed its accuracy and calibration. Importantly, both albumin and lactate dehydrogenase are not included in the most recent MSKCC and Heng prognostic models [10], which may therefore be less accurate in selecting patients for surgery than the nomogram.

We hope you will enjoy reading those papers as much as we did while preparing this topic issue.

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